

Bob Ingram

'As I Was Saying ...'

Old Weaver habit

A KENYAN WITCH doctor didn't help any and Hurricane Eloise has been a deterring factor. So, it looks like Earl Weaver is running out of time in his fight to overtake the Boston Red Sox in the American League East race.

The mere fact that the Baltimore Orioles are coming down to the wire almost abreast of the Red Sox is quite a tribute to his Earliship, however.

Baltimore stumbled and sputtered badly early in this season. After watching the Orioles give one inept performance on TV, I said to myself, "Earl will never make it this year."

But here he is three and a half games behind the Red Sox with seven games left to play. His Orioles have won 10 out of their last 11. They still have a mathematical chance. They haven't given up.

If Earl pulls it off, it will be his sixth divisional championship in eight and a half seasons as the Oriole manager. He has won three American League pennants and one World Series. Even if he doesn't win the East this year, Weaver has done quite well as a manager, being that the never went to bat as a player in the majors.

His interference

ANDY COHEN is not surprised at Weaver's success as a manager.

Weaver was a little firebrand second baseman for Andy on the Denver club of the Western League in 1954 and with the New Orleans Pelicans in the Southern Assn., in 1955.

"Bob Howsam (general manager of the Denver Bears then and now president of the Cincinnati Reds) and I liked the way Weaver was playing at Omaha," said Andy. "So, we arranged a trade and got him for the Bears."

"He was a battler, a bulldog. I liked his spunk. He was not an over-talented player but he played with great determination."

Andy recalls one incident in which Weaver's intensity and desire to win backfired.

"We were playing against Wichita," said Andy. "Weaver had gotten to second base. We had a runner on first. Our batter drove a ball toward the Wichita shortstop. It was a perfect double play ball."

"Weaver tried to bother the shortstop. He danced momentarily in front of the ball and stuck his hand down to obscure the shortstop's view. Darn if the ball didn't hit him square in the hand. He made a perfect pickup."

"Of course, he was called out. There was no argument about that. But the umpire called the player who hit the ball out, too."

"Earl and I both argued hotly about it. But the umpire's ruling stuck. And he was right, too."

Organization man

"WELL, EARL, I said, that was the best play you made this year. The only thing is that you made it for the other side."

"Earl replied, 'yeah, I know. I guess I simply overhustled.'"

"With New Orleans, Earl played three positions in a game with Chatanooga, second base, outfield and catcher. He could play anywhere."

Speaking of Weaver's managerial career, Andy said, "I don't think he's had the recognition he deserves. He's been bypassed several times in the voting for the manager of the year."

Weaver has been compared to Billy Martin. Each has a fiery combativeness and competitiveness. There's one difference. While Billy M. falls out with the front office after a year or two and is fired, Weaver is a strong organization man who causes no problem in the administrative end.

There's some talk about Weaver's contract not being renewed at Baltimore. In the event that there is a separation, Weaver isn't likely to add to the unemployment woes of this country very long.

Brown University in Providence, R.I., was originally called Rhode Island College.

